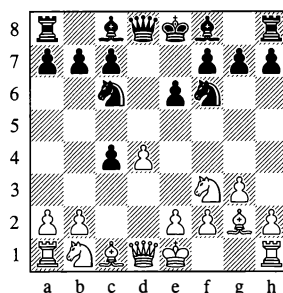


Chapter 11

Catalan 4...dxc4



5...♘c6

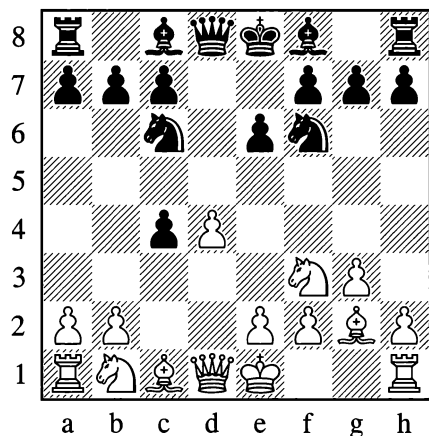
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1.d4 ♘f6 2.c4 e6 3.g3 d5 4.♘f3 dxc4 5.♙g2 ♘c6

6.♙a4

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1.d4 ♖f6 2.c4 e6 3.g3 d5 4.♖f3 dxc4 5.♗g2 ♖c6



6.♞a4

This chapter resembles the corresponding chapter of *GM 1*. Broadly speaking, I have mostly recommended the same basic lines for White, but with some fine tuning based on more recent games and analysis.

Black has four main options: **A) 6...♗d6**, **B) 6...♗d7**, **C) 6...♖d7** and **D) 6...♗b4†**.

6...♖d5 7.♞xc4 ♖b6 takes us directly to variation C.

A) 6...♗d6

This is a pretty rare choice, but it is quite natural to develop while preparing ...e5.

7.♖e5!?

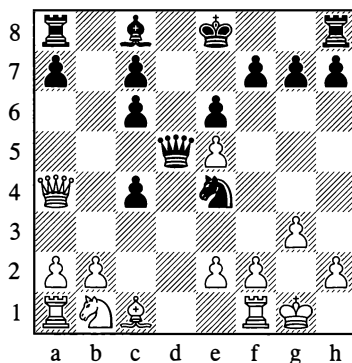
7.♖bd2 was my recommendation in *GM 1*, but after 7...0–0 8.♖xc4 Black came up with a useful improvement in 8...♞b8!, when 9.♖xd6 cxd6 10.0–0 b5 11.♞b3 ♗b7 led to equality in Evans – Buczinski, email 2010.

7...♗xe5

7...0–0?! 8.♖xc6 bxc6 9.♖d2 will lead to a serious positional plus for White after he regains the c4-pawn.

8.♗xc6† bxc6 9.dxe5 ♖d7

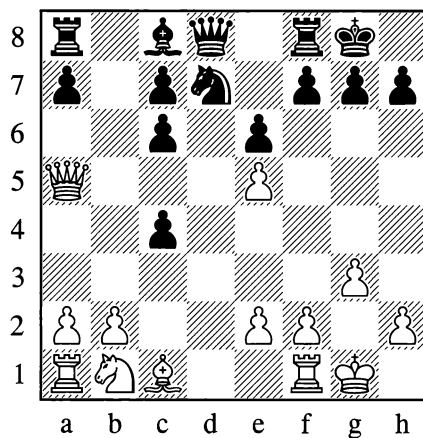
9...♞d5 10.0–0 ♖e4 has also been played. A similar situation can arise via the 6...♗b4† 7.♗d2 ♗d6 variation, but there exists a vital difference: the bishop is not hanging on d2 here! This allows White to seize the initiative as follows:



11.♖a3! (This important move would obviously not be available with the bishop on d2 instead of c1. That is why, in variation D1 on page 160, I recommend a different course of action with ♖a3 instead of ♖e5 a few moves earlier.) 11...♖c5 12.♞a5! 0–0 13.♗e3 ♖d7 14.♞xc7 c3 15.bxc3 White was clearly better in Ragger – Baumegeger, Vienna 2010.

10.0–0 0–0 11.♞a5!

Here too, this is an excellent move.

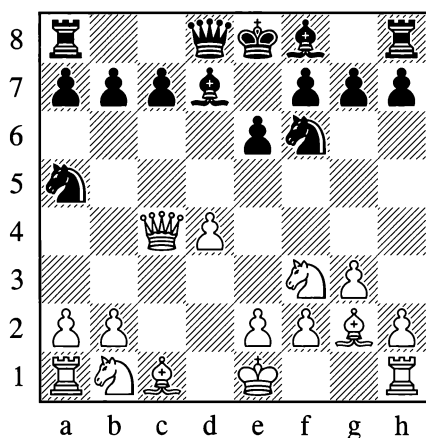


11...♖b8

Another game continued 11...f6 12.♖d1 fxe5 13.♜c3 and Black's pawn structure was a sorry sight in Sherwood – Keevil, Internet 2012.

12.♖d1 f6 13.♜a3 c3 14.b3 fxe5 15.♙e3±

White was much better in a game between engines with unknown names.

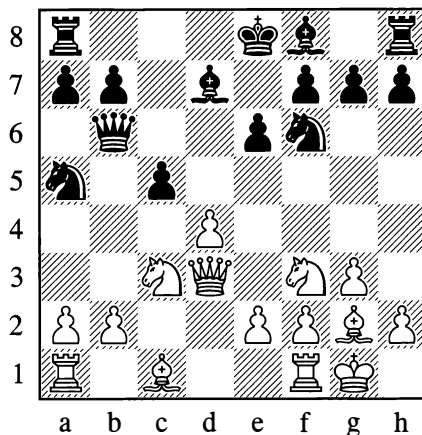
B) 6...♙d7 7.♖xc4 ♜a5

Objectively this line is not so bad for Black, but it does not lead to full equality and has fallen completely out of fashion.

8.♖d3 c5 9.0-0

This is a significant branching point, where Black's main options are **B1) 9...♖b6**, **B2) 9...♖c8** and **B3) 9...♙c6**.

9...c4? can be considered an inferior version of variation C1 of Chapter 7, which can be found on page 94, as Black has played the decentralizing...♜a5 instead of the more useful ...b5. Here is the model example: 10.♖c2 ♙c6 11.♜c3 ♙b4 12.♙g5 0-0 13.♖ad1 h6 14.d5 exd5 15.♙xf6 ♖xf6 16.♜xd5 ♙xd5 17.♖xd5± Black's minor pieces were badly misplaced on the queenside in P.H. Nielsen – Hjartarson, Copenhagen 1996.

B1) 9...♖b6 10.♜c3**10...cxd4**

The alternative is:

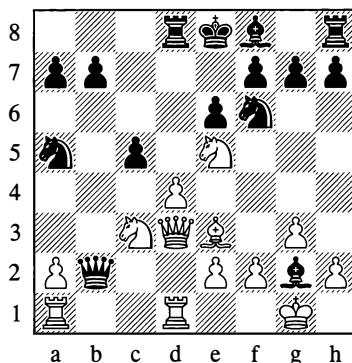
10...♙c6 11.♙e3 ♖d8

The b2-pawn is obviously poisoned: 11...♖xb2? 12.♜e5 ♙xg2 13.♖ab1 ♖a3 14.♜xg2 and Black is just lost.

12.♖fd1 ♖xb2?

This pawn grab is too dangerous.

White is also better after other moves, for instance: 12...cxd4N 13.♜xd4 (13.♙xd4 is also promising.) 13...♙xg2 14.♜xg2 ♙e7 15.♜a4 ♖b4 16.♖b5! ♜c6 17.♖xb4 ♜xb4 18.♜b5!↑

13.♜e5 ♙xg2**14.♖ab1! ♖a3 15.♜xg2**

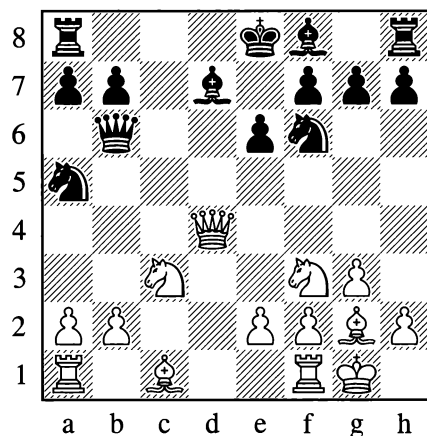
White was winning, and he smashed his opponent in a few more moves:

15...♖c6 16.♖b5 ♖xc3 17.♖xc6 bxc6
18.♖xc6† ♖d7 19.dxc5+–

Golombek – Ed. Lasker, Hastings 1953.

11.♖xd4

11.♖xd4 ♖c5 12.♖e3 ♖g4 looks fine for Black.



11...♖xd4

11...♖c5 12.♖h4! produces a surprising transposition to variation B11 of Chapter 7 (with one extra move played here) – see page 90.

12.♖xd4 ♖c5

Now I like the following slightly surprising idea.

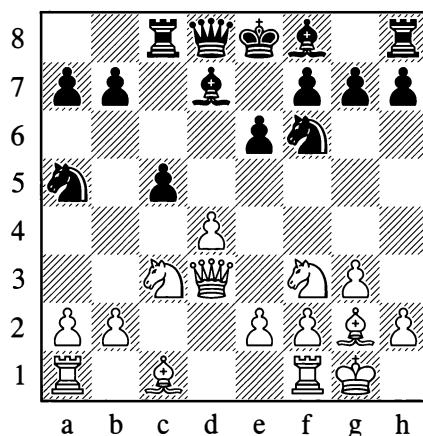
13.♖b3!? ♖xb3 14.axb3

White has serious pressure on the queenside, for instance:

14...♖e7 15.♖f4 ♖c6 16.♖xc6 bxc6 17.♖a6 ♖b6 18.♖a4 ♖d5 19.♖a1 ♖ad8 20.♖xb6 axb6 21.♖e5!±

Black was in real trouble in M. Grabarczyk – Taimanov, Germany 2002.

B2) 9...♖c8 10.♖c3



10...cxd4

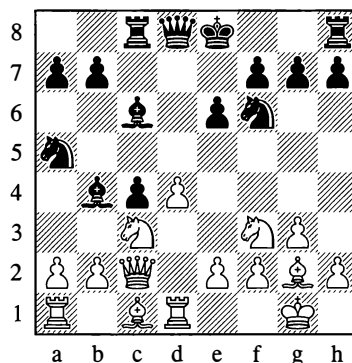
Another direction is:

10...♖c6 11.♖d1 c4

11...cxd4 12.♖xd4 ♖xg2 13.♖xg2 ♖c5 14.♖b5†! causes problems before Black can complete his development: 14...♖d7 (14...♖d7 15.♖g5! practically decides the game instantly, for example: 15...♖b6 16.♖f5! ♖xb5 17.♖xg7† ♖f8 18.♖xb5+–) 15.♖xd7† ♖xd7 16.♖e4 ♖c4 (16...♖e7 17.♖b5± is also bad for Black.) 17.b3 ♖ce5 18.♖b5! Black was losing at least a pawn in Nogly – Halasz, Dortmund 1992.

12.♖c2 ♖b4

Black is trying to control the light squares and restrain White's central pawns, but the next move shatters that illusion.



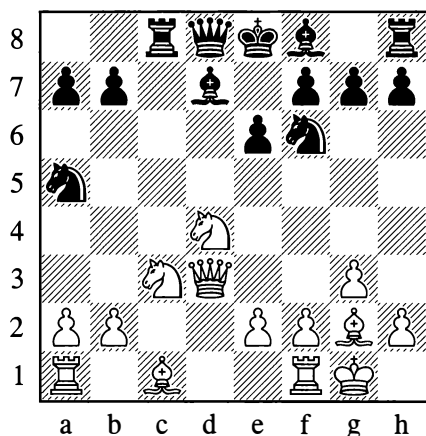
13.d5! exd5 14.e4 0-0

14...♙xc3?! 15.exd5 ♖xd5 16.bxc3 0-0
17.♘g5 g6 was even worse in Ftacnik –
Lechtynsky, Czechoslovakia 1979. Here the
simple 18.♙f4!N ♜e8 19.♞d4 would have
given Black serious trouble along the d-file.

15.exd5 ♙d7 16.♙f4 b5 17.♘e5±

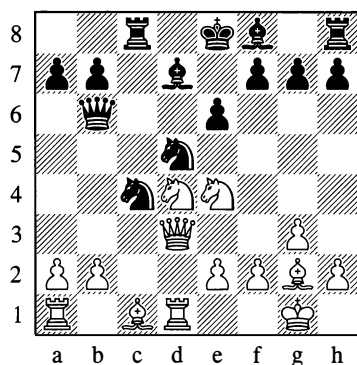
White's advantage was obvious in Gofshtein
– Berkovich, USSR 1976.

11.♘xd4



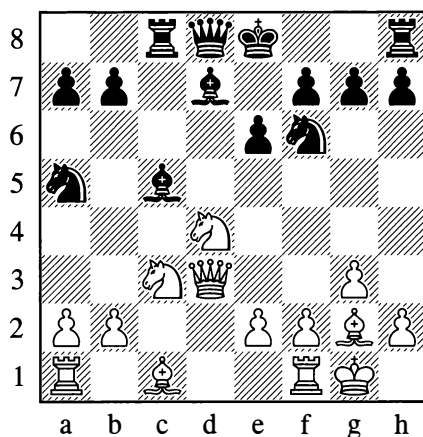
11...♙c5

11...♙b6 has been played almost as often.
12.♞d1 ♖c4 (12...♙e7 13.♘e4 ♖d5 14.♘f5!
exf5 15.♙xd5 ♙e6 16.♘d6† ♙xd6 17.♙xd6
♙xd6 18.♞xd6 ♖e7 19.♞d1 ♞hd8 20.♙d2
♖c6 21.b3± White kept an edge thanks to the
bishop pair in Schueppen – Feco, email 2010.)
13.♘e4 ♖d5 Now in Schuster – Shpakovsky,
email 2009, White could have developed his
initiative with:



14.♘g5! The key idea is 14...h6 15.♘dxe6!
♙xe6 16.♘xe6 fxe6 17.♙e4!!, an amazingly
calm move which would be hard to find over
the board. 17...♘f6 18.♙g6† ♖e7 19.b3
White has an extremely dangerous initiative
for the sacrificed piece.

The text move is more solid for Black, and was
played in Gustafsson – Groszpeter, Austria
2005, and several subsequent games. In *GM 1*
I gave 12.♞d1 as a novelty leading to an edge
for White, which seems like a valid assessment,
but in practice Black has been quite successful
neutralizing White's slight pressure. Therefore
I would like to propose a new direction
here.



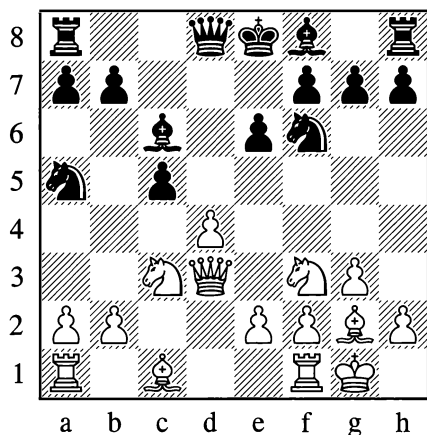
12.♘e4!N ♖xe4

12...♙e7 13.♘xf6† ♙xf6 14.♘b5† is
problematic for Black, as both of his queenside
pawns are under attack.

13.♙xe4 ♙c6 14.♘xc6 ♙xd3 15.♙xd3 ♘xc6
16.♞d1 ♖e7 17.♙g2 ♞hd8 18.♙d2±

Black is unable to do anything special with
his slight lead in development. White will soon
get coordinated, and his bishop pair provides
real chances for a long-term pull.

B3) 9...♙c6 10.♘c3

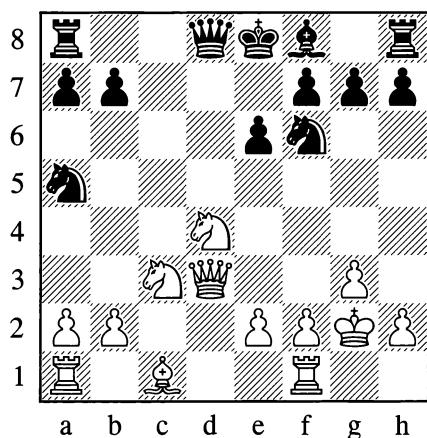


Now Black can either remove the central tension with **B31) 10...cxd4** or maintain it with **B32) 10...♗e7**.

B31) 10...cxd4 11.♖xd4 ♗xg2

11...♗c5 12.♞d1 ♗xd4 (12...♗xg2 13.♞b5†! ♖d7 14.♗xg2 transposes to 11...♗xg2 12.♗xg2 ♗c5 13.♞b5†! ♖d7 14.♞d1, as covered in the main line below.) 13.♞xd4 ♞xd4 14.♞xd4 ♗xg2 15.♗xg2 ♖c6 16.♞d1± White keeps a pleasant edge in this endgame.

12.♗xg2

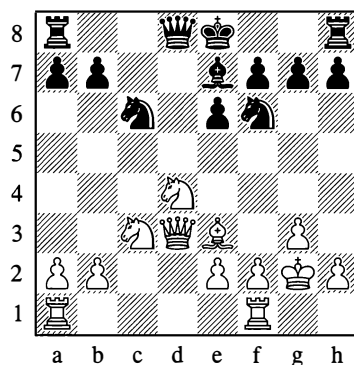


12...♗c5

12...a6 is no better: 13.♞d1 ♗e7 (13...♗c5 transposes to 15...♖f6 in the notes to the

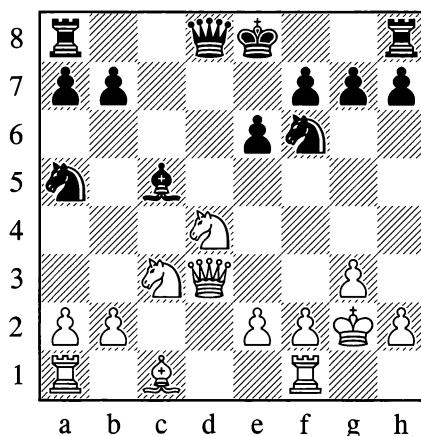
main line, with two fewer moves played – see 12...♗c5 13.♞b5†! ♖d7 14.♞d1 a6 15.♞d3 ♖f6 below.) 14.♞f3 White had an obvious initiative in Solari – Rivas Mongrut, corr. 2007.

12...♖c6 was played in Antic – Lazarevic, Niska Banja 1996. Here the only chance for White to fight for the advantage is 13.♗e3!N, as pointed out by Marin. Play may continue: 13...♗e7 (13...♖xd4? 14.♗xd4 ♗e7 15.♞b5†! ♞d7 16.♞xd7† ♗xd7 17.♞fd1 ♗e8 18.♖b5 leaves Black in serious trouble.)



14.♞fd1 This looks like the best way to develop White's initiative. 14...♞c8 (After 14...♞d7 15.♞c4 ♖e5 16.♞b5 ♗xb5 17.♖dxb5 0-0 18.♗xa7± White safely grabs a pawn.) 15.♞ac1 0-0 16.♖e4± White has a pleasant edge which may easily become more serious.

The text move runs into a thematic idea.



13. ♖b5! ♜d7 14. ♞d1

14. ♜f3!?N

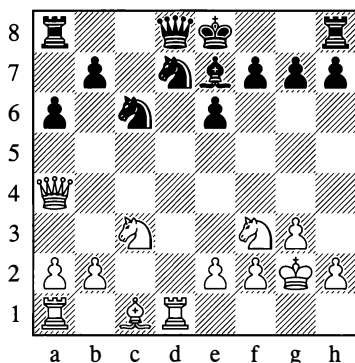
This new idea may be even stronger. However, I have kept the rook move as the main line because Black can also reach it via the 11...♙c5 or 12...a6 move orders, as noted earlier.

14...a6

14...♙b6 15. ♞d1 ♜c6 16. ♙a4! ♞d8 17. ♙g4! gives White a clear advantage.

15. ♙a4 ♙e7 16. ♞d1 ♜c6

16...b5 17. ♙e4 leaves Black in an unpleasant pin along the d-file. An important detail is that 17...♙c8 can be met by 18. ♞xd7! ♜xd7 19. ♙d4† ♜e8 20. ♙xg7 ♞f8 21. ♙h6 with a huge advantage.



17. ♙b3 ♜a5

17...b5 18. ♜e4 0-0 19. ♜fg5±

18. ♙c2 ♙c8

18...0-0? allows 19. ♜e5±.

19. ♙f4 0-0 20. ♞ac1±

Black has managed to castle, but he is a long way from equalizing, as White's pieces are much better placed.

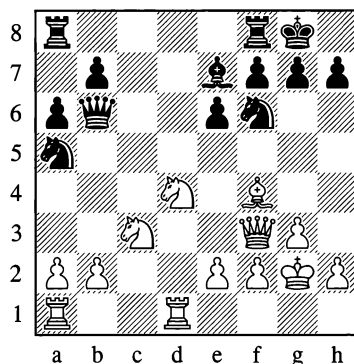
14...a6 15. ♙d3 ♞c8

This move has been played at World Championship level, but it does not solve Black's problems.

15...♙e7 16. ♙f4 ♞c8 (16...0-0? allows 17. ♜xe6!) 17. ♜f3 ♜c4 18. ♜a4 b5 19. b3 ♜cb6 20. ♜xb6 ♜xb6 21. ♙xd8† ♙xd8 Black

has managed to simplify, but after 22.e4 he still faced an unpleasant endgame in Tkachiev – Solozhenkin, France 2000.

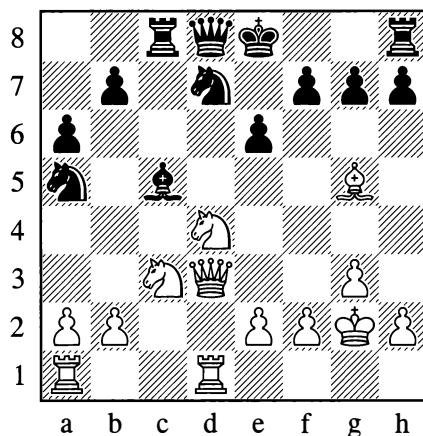
15...♜f6 is the most solid choice for Black, but it still does not equalize. 16. ♙e3 (It is also worth considering 16. ♙g5!?, for instance 16...♙xd4 17. ♙xd4 ♙xd4 18. ♞xd4 ♜c6 19. ♞d3 ♞d8 20. ♞xd8† ♜xd8 21. ♜e4 ♜e7 22. ♜c5 ♞b8 23. a3± and White maintains nagging pressure) 16...♙e7 17. ♙f4 0-0 18. ♙f3 ♙b6 This position occurred in Villar Ramos – Semenov, email 2007. Here I suggest:



19. b3N ♞ac8 20. ♜a4 ♙a7 21. ♙e3 ♙b8 22. ♜b6 ♞cd8 23. ♙f4 ♙d6 24. ♙d2 ♙c5 25. ♙xa5 ♙xd4 26. ♞ac1 White maintains a pleasant edge.

16. ♙g5!

A very nice move, which gives White the opportunity to seize a dangerous initiative.



16...♗f6N

The bishop is untouchable: 16...♖xg5? 17.♘xe6 ♖e7 18.♘g7† ♔d8 19.♘d5 with a decisive attack.

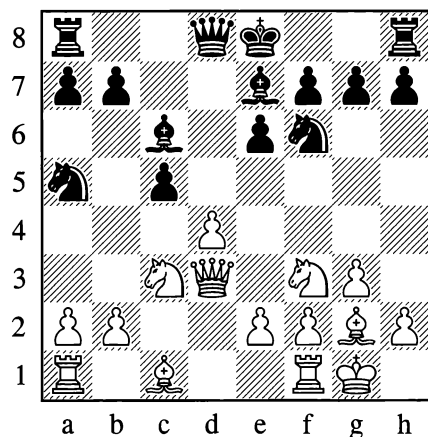
16...♗e7 was played in Kramnik – Topalov, Elista (3) 2006, and now 17.♘e4! would have given White a considerable advantage, as mentioned in numerous sources.

17.♗xf6 gxf6

17...♖xf6? runs into 18.♘e4 ♖xd4 (18...♖e7 loses to 19.♖c3!) 19.♖xd4 ♗xd4 20.♘d6†+– winning an exchange.

18.♖e4 ♖e7 19.♖g4

White is clearly better.

B32) 10...♗e7

By refraining from exchanges, Black avoids the possibility of an unpleasant check on b5.

11.♗d1 0–0

If Black switches to the other plan, he runs into a familiar problem:

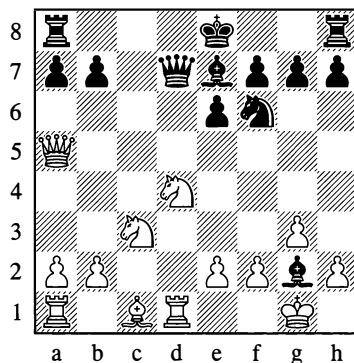
11...cxd4 12.♘xd4 ♗xg2 13.♖b5†!

Once again, this intermediate check allows White to seize the initiative.

13...♖d7 14.♖xa5!N

14.♘xg2 ♖xb5 15.♘cxb5 0–0 16.♗f4 a6

allowed Black to escape with equality in Ilincic – Brkic, Teslic 2006, but the text move keeps him under real pressure.



14...♗d5 15.♘xd5 ♘xd5

After 15...exd5 16.♗f4 0–0 17.♖b5! Black has no activity to compensate for the isolated pawn.

16.e4 ♗b4

16...♘f6 17.♗f4 also gives White a significant plus.

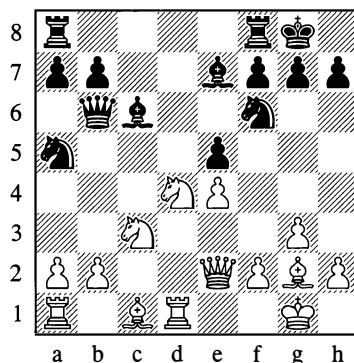
17.♖b5 ♖xb5 18.♘xb5 a6 19.exd5 axb5 20.♗f4

Black is under pressure and it will be hard for him to avoid the loss of a pawn.

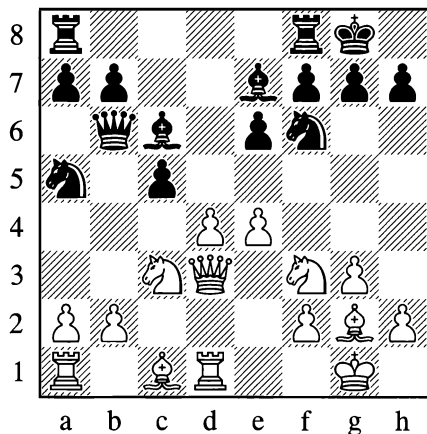
12.e4 ♖b6

This is definitely Black's best.

12...cxd4?! 13.♘xd4 ♖b6 has been played in a few more games, but it is significantly inferior. 14.♖e2 is a good answer, and now 14...e5? made things even worse in Govchiyan – Sulava, Nice 2004. For some reason, White avoided the obvious and strong:



15. ♖f5N ♙c5 16. ♙g5 ♘e8 17. ♗ab1! With a decisive advantage.



13. ♙e3 ♗fd8

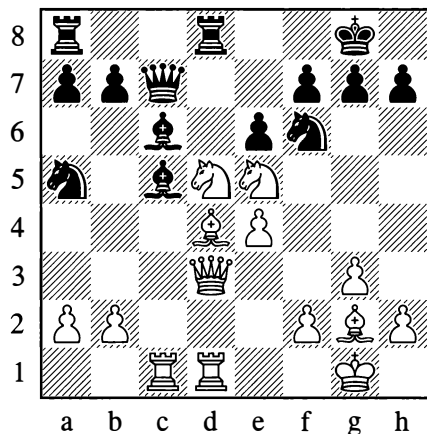
So far nobody has played the risky 13... ♗xb2N, and indeed after 14.d5 c4 (14... ♗fd8? loses to 15. ♗ab1 ♗a3 16. ♙c1!) 15. ♗d4 ♙b4 16. ♙d2 White is clearly better.

14. ♘e5 cxd4 15. ♙xd4 ♗c7?!

An unfortunate square for the queen. The lesser evil was 15... ♗b4N, although after 16. ♗e3 ♘c4 17. ♘xc4 ♗xc4 18. ♙f3! White maintains the better chances.

16. ♗ac1 ♙c5 17. ♘d5!

The clever point of this move is not so much the simple tactical justification of winning back the piece, but rather about the evaluation of the position two moves later.



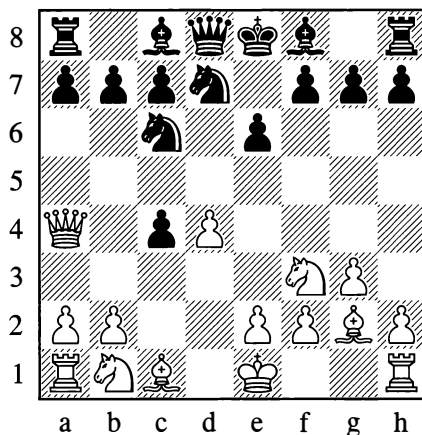
17...exd5 18. ♗xc5 ♘xe4 19. ♗cc1

Despite the extra pawn, Black's position is quite unstable, and in the game he went down quickly.

19... ♗e7 20. ♘g4!? b6 21. ♘e3 ♗e6? 22. b4 ♘c4 23. ♙xe4

Black suffered a fatal loss of material in Eljanov – Goloshchapov, Dubai 2014.

C) 6... ♘d7



With this concrete approach, Black forces White to take on c4, and intends to attack the queen and create active play in the centre.

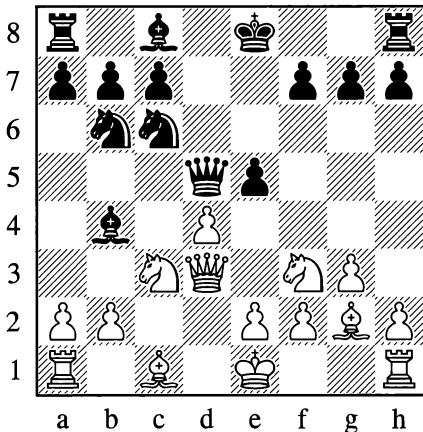
7. ♗xc4 ♘b6 8. ♗b5!

I consider this idea of Tkachiev to be White's only real chance for an opening advantage. The idea is to provoke ...a6 in order to destabilize the knight on b6, which may prove useful for White in some endgame positions. Black has three main moves: C1) 8... ♙b4†, C2) 8... ♙d7 and C3) 8...a6.

8... ♗d5 9. ♘c3 leaves Black with nothing better than 9... ♙b4, transposing to variation C1 below.

C1) 8...♙b4† 9.♟c3 ♖d5 10.♞d3 e5

This concrete approach is the idea behind bringing the queen to d5. If instead 10...♞c4 11.♞xc4 ♟xc4 12.0–0± White enjoys a pleasant endgame.

**11.0–0**

11.e4 ♞c4 is fine for Black.

11...♙xc3 12.♟xe5!

This is the only way to fight for the advantage.

After 12.bxc3 e4 13.♞e3 f5 Black has a comfortable position with full control over the light squares.

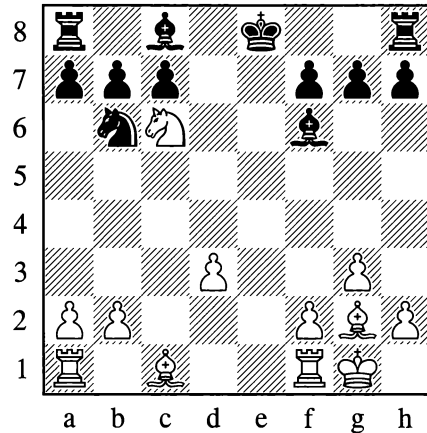
12...♞xd4 13.♟xc6!

In *GM 1* I gave 13.♙xc6† bxc6 14.♞xc3 ♞xc3 15.bxc3 as my main recommendation, believing that White had a risk-free edge. However, some time afterwards I noticed that 15...c5!N should enable Black to hold without too many problems. (Instead 15...♟a4 16.c4 ♙e6 17.♙e3 gave White a pleasant edge in Roiz – Gofshtein, Israel 2007.)

I also considered the text move in the notes in *GM 1*, and have updated the analysis here to take into account a recent game.

13...♞xd3 14.exd3 ♙f6

White retains a clear advantage after 14...♙d7 15.bxc3 ♙xc6 16.♞e1† ♟d8 (or 16...♟d7 17.♙h3† ♟d8 18.♙e3 ♟d5 19.♙d4±) 17.♙xc6 bxc6 18.♙a3±.

**15.♞e1† ♟f8**

In the event of 15...♙e6N 16.♟a5 0–0 17.♙xb7 ♖ad8 18.♙e4 Black is a pawn down for no compensation.

16.♟e5

Previously I recommended this as a novelty, and it has since been tested in one game.

16...g5

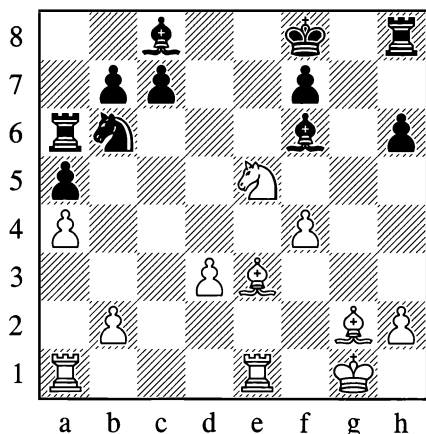
16...c6 was the move I analysed in *GM 1*, as it seemed like the most obvious try to develop Black's queenside. However, after 17.a4 White keeps the initiative everywhere, for instance: 17...♙xe5 (or 17...g5 18.a5 ♟d5 19.a6 ♟g7 20.axb7 ♙xb7 21.♟g4 with advantage for White) 18.♞xe5 f6 19.♞a5 ♙e6 20.♙e3 ♟f7 21.b4 and Black remains under pressure.

In the following game Black tried to organize his pieces in a different way, but he still failed to equalize.

17.a4 a5 18.f4 h6 19.♙e3 gxf4 20.gxf4 ♖a6 20...♙e7N looks better, although after

21.♖ac1 ♕d6 22.♙xb6 cxb6 23.d4± White has a pleasant, risk-free edge.

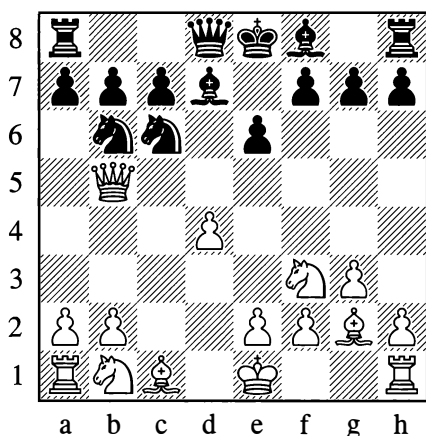
We have been following the game Perez Ponsa – Tristan, Resistance/Saenz Pena 2013. Here White could have obtained a serious advantage by means of:



21.♙c5+ Nc8 22.♙h1±

Preparing to use the open g-file. Black is under pressure across the board.

C2) 8...♙d7



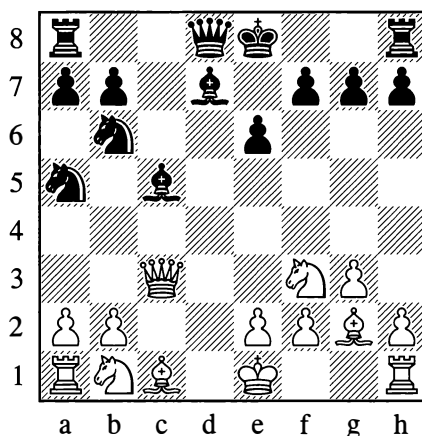
Black logically breaks the pin and chases the queen away, but at the same time he blocks the pressure against the d4-pawn and allows White to arrange his pieces comfortably.

9.♖b3 ♕a5

This is the principled follow-up, although the modest 9...♙d6 seems like the best way to minimize Black's disadvantage. 10.0–0 0–0 11.♖c3 a5 occurred in Zueger – Ekstroem, Switzerland 2007, and now the simple 12.♖c2 N a4 13.e4 e5 14.dxe5 ♖xe5 15.♖xe5 ♙xe5 16.♙e3 would have given White the better game.

10.♖d3 c5 11.dxc5 ♙xc5 12.♖c3!

This triple attack poses serious problems.



12...♖c8

This tactical defence does not quite work, but the alternative 12...♖d5 13.♖xg7 ♖f6 14.♖xf6 ♖xf6 15.♖e5 just leaves Black a pawn down for no compensation.

13.♖xg7 ♙f8

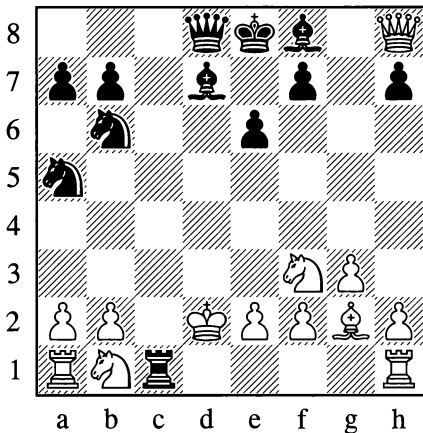
This position first occurred in Kramnik – Naiditsch, Dortmund 2006, when, unbelievably, White did not capture the rook.

14.♖xh8!

Instead Vladimir settled for 14.♖g5 ♖xg5 15.♙xg5 ♙g7, when Black was perfectly okay.

14...♖xc1† 15.♖d2

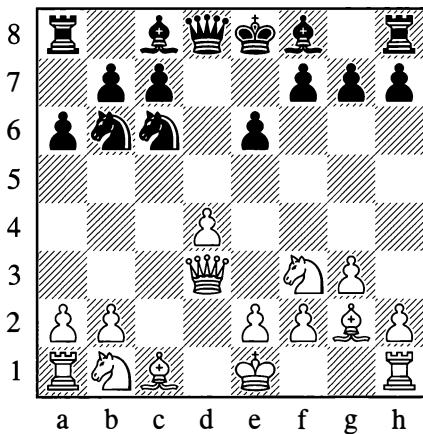
No doubt the position looks a bit scary, but the white queen can always come back to d4 to block the discovered check.



15...♖c5 16.♖c3 ♖bc4† 17.♗e1

White was winning in Khenkin – Martinsen, Dresden 2006.

C3) 8...a6 9.♗d3

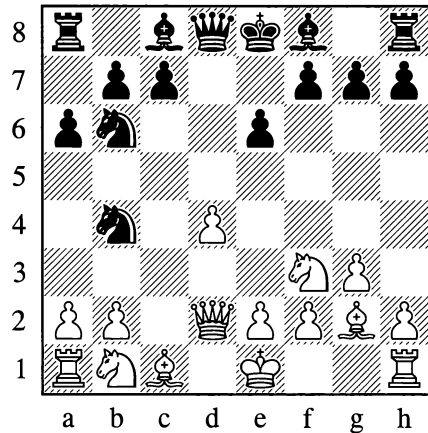


This is the main line, where White hopes to benefit from having provoked Black's last move. Now C31) 9...♖b4 is a fresh idea that has been tested a few times since *GM 1* was published. The most popular move, however, is still C32) 9...e5.

C31) 9...♖b4 10.♗d2!

This is the best square for the queen. 10.♗d1 can be met by the interesting reply: 10...e5!?

(10...c5 11.0-0 cxd4 12.♖xd4 e5 13.a3 exd4 14.axb4 ♖xb4 was also decent for Black in Houriez – Anikaev, Figueres 2011) 11.a3N (11.♖a3?! exd4 12.♗xd4 ♗xd4 13.♖xd4 occurred in Batsiashvili – Pouloupoulos, Kavala 2013, and now the accurate 13...♖e7N 14.0-0 0-0 leaves Black with no problems in the arising endgame) 11...e4 With complex play.



10...c5

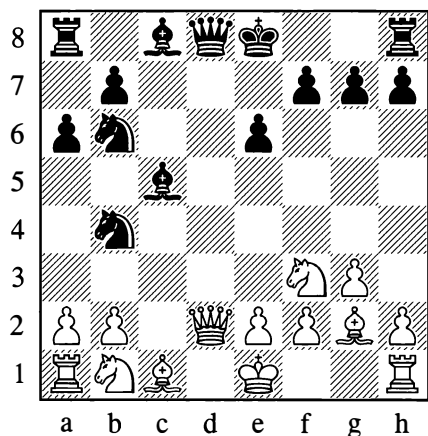
I only found one game in the database from the above position, which was contested by two computer engines. I considered a couple of other candidate moves:

10...e5?! 11.a3 e4 12.axb4 exf3 13.♖xf3 is clearly better for White.

10...♖e7 11.a3 ♖c6 12.0-0 0-0 13.♖c3± gives White a comfortable edge.

11.dxc5 ♖xc5

Exchanging queens only helps White to develop: 11...♗xd2† 12.♖xd2 ♖xc5 (After 12...♖c2†? 13.♗d1 ♖xa1 14.cxb6± White will soon pick up the knight in the corner.) 13.0-0 0-0 14.♖c1 ♖d6 15.♖c3± White maintains solid pressure in the endgame – just compare the Catalan bishop to its undeveloped counterpart on c8.



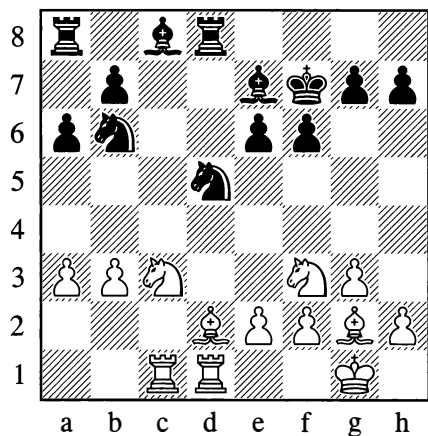
12.0-0 0-0 13.♖c3 ♜xd2

Avoiding the queen trade with 13...♞c7 does not solve Black's problems. 14.a3 ♘d4 15.♘xd5 ♘xd5 16.b4 ♙b6 17.♞b2! White keeps a nice pull.

14.♙xd2 ♙e7 15.♞ac1 ♞d8 16.♞fd1

Normally it would be enough to stop here and say that White has the more pleasant game, as all his pieces are in play, while Black has yet to solve the typical problem of his light-squared bishop. However, it is worth showing a few more moves of the computer game, as it featured a remarkable idea.

16...f6 17.b3!? ♙f7 18.a3 ♘d4 19.♙xd5 ♘xd5 20.e4 ♙b6 21.♙e3



19.♘b1!!

Suddenly it becomes clear that Black's knights are poorly placed.

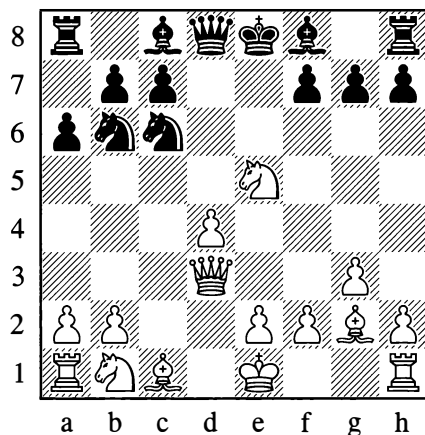
19...♘d7 20.e4 ♙b6 21.♙e3

White was clearly better in Hannibal – Deep Junior, Internet 2012.

C32) 9...e5 10.♘xe5

I once played 10.♙e3 and scored a good victory after 10...exd4 11.♘xd4 ♘xd4 12.♞xd4 ♞xd4 13.♙xd4 ♙b4† 14.♘c3 0-0 15.0-0-0 in Avrukh – Berg, Santa Cruz de la Palma 2005. This game nicely illustrates the usefulness of provoking the ...a6 move, as the knight on b6 has become vulnerable, and Black is unable to stabilize his queenside with ...c6.

Unfortunately, as I noted in *GM 1*, Black can improve with 10...♘b4!, when both 11.♞e4 ♞d5 and 11.♞d1 exd4 12.♘xd4 c5 should be fine for him.



10...♘b4

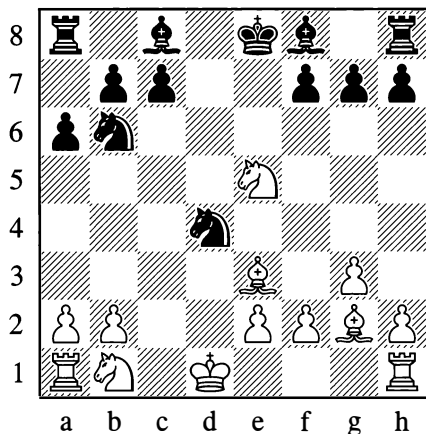
This has been played in all games so far. 10...♘xd4N 11.♙e3! c5 gives White more than one route to an advantage; even the simplistic 12.♙xd4!? (12.♘d2 is more ambitious) 12...♞xd4 13.♞xd4 cxd4 14.♘d2± gives White a slightly better endgame with virtually no risk.

11. ♖c3 ♗xd4 12. ♗xd4

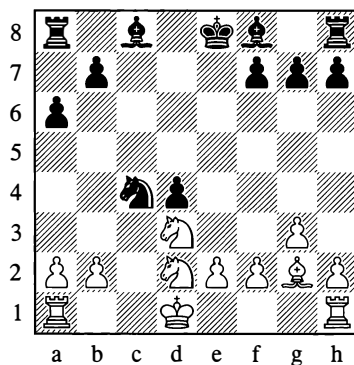
12. ♗xc7 is less convincing: 12... ♙e7 (The ambitious 12... ♙e6!? can also be considered) 13. ♖f3 ♗c4 14. ♗xc4 ♖xc4 15. ♖d4 ♙f6 16. a3 ♖xa3! 17. ♖xa3 ♙xd4 18. 0–0 0–0 Black has held this position in a couple of correspondence games.

12... ♖c2† 13. ♖d1 ♖xd4 14. ♙e3

I have always felt that this was a pleasant position for White, who enjoys a slight pull without much risk.

**14... ♖f5**

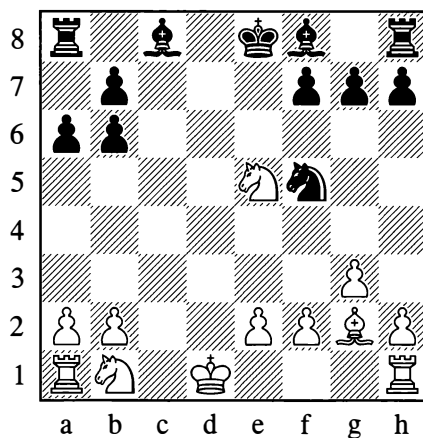
14...c5 occurred in one game, Brandstetter – Neubauer, Graz 2012. Strategically, this consolidation of the knight in the centre looks risky, as several light squares have now been weakened. In principle, White would like to exchange on d4 at an appropriate moment, obtaining the excellent d3-square for his e5-knight, but there is no hurry for the time being. I propose 15. ♖d3!N in order to put the c5-pawn under observation and prevent Black from moving his knight away from d4 – especially to f5. 15... ♖c4 16. ♙xd4 cxd4 17. ♖d2



17... ♖d6 (In the event of 17... ♖xd2 18. ♖xd2 it will be hard for Black to cope with the activation of a rook along the c-file, for instance: 18... ♙d6 19. ♗hc1 ♖e7 20. ♗c4±) 18. ♗c1± The arising endgame is quite unpleasant for Black.

15. ♙xb6 cxb6

White's superior pawn structure gives him a strategic advantage, but Black's bishop pair should not be underestimated.

**16. ♖c3**

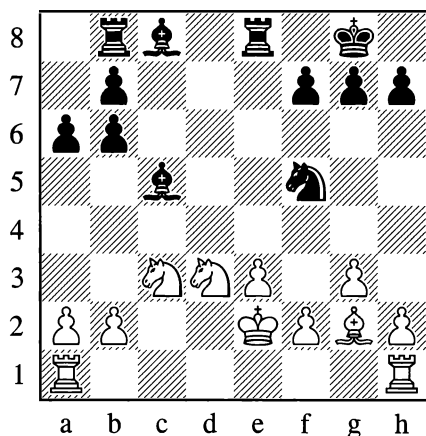
In *GM 1* I recommended 16. ♖d2, but have since changed my mind about White's optimal set-up.

16... ♙c5 17. e3 0–0 18. ♖e2 ♗e8 19. ♖d3 ♗b8

19... ♙d6?! significantly eases White's task. 20. ♖d5 b5 21. ♖b6 ♗b8 22. ♖xc8 ♗exc8

23.♖h3 g6 24.♙xf5 gxf5 25.♞ac1 It will be hard for Black to hold the endgame with such a damaged pawn structure.

At this point I would like to suggest a surprising new idea.



20.♟xc5!N

20.♞hc1 led to an eventual success for White in Kramnik – Naiditsch, Dortmund 2007, but 20...♙f8N 21.♟d5 b5 would have led to a tense position.

20...bxc5 21.♞hd1 ♙e6 22.♟d5

White has received some clear benefits in return for improving the enemy pawn structure. Black no longer has the bishop pair, and White has reached a completely safe position where he keeps long-term pressure. Here is a nice illustrative line.

22...b6

Otherwise ♟b6 will leave Black in a bind.

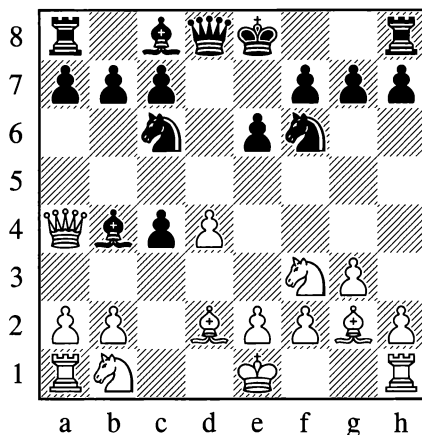
23.♟c7 ♙c4† 24.♙e1 ♞e7 25.♟d5 ♙xd5

25...♞e6?! is worse: 26.♙h3 ♟d4 27.♞xd4! cxd4 28.♙xe6 fxe6 29.♟e7† ♙f8 30.♟c6 ♞c8 31.♟xd4±

26.♞xd5 g6 27.♞ad1±

Black is doomed to a passive defence.

D) 6...♙b4† 7.♙d2



From here Black sometimes tries D1) 7...♙d6, but the main line is D2) 7...♟d5.

D1) 7...♙d6

This is not a trendy move, but it is played from time to time by strong grandmasters. There have been only minor developments since I analysed it in *GM 1*.

8.♟a3

Surprisingly, this remains in the shadow of more popular moves such as 8.♟e5 and 8.0–0. It is highly desirable to capture the c4-pawn with the knight, as this will significantly complicate Black's idea of freeing his position with ...e5.

We will focus on D11) 8...♟e4 and D12) 8...♙xa3, after having a look at Black's other possibilities:

8...♙d7 9.♟xc4 ♟e4 10.♞b3!N (10.e3 was played in Khotenashvili – Tregubov, Konya 2012, but this unnecessarily allows Black to simplify with 10...♟e5!N) 10...♟xd2 11.♟cxd2 0–0 12.0–0 e5 13.d5 ♟e7 (13...♟d4? is hardly a good idea in view of 14.♟xd4 exd4 15.♟f3 ♞f6 16.♞fd1± when the d4-pawn falls) 14.♟c4 White has a pleasant edge.

8...a6?! 9.♖e5!

9.♖xc4 b5 10.♖xd6† cxd6 11.♞a3 ♗b7∞ is reasonable for Black.

9...♗d7

9...♗xe5 10.♗xc6† bxc6 11.dxe5 is clearly better for White.

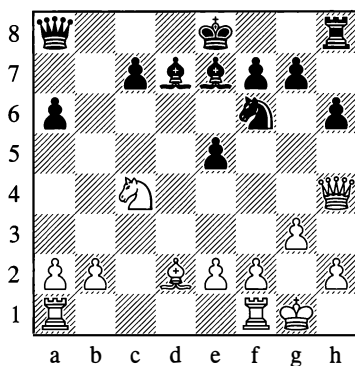
10.♖xc6 bxc6 11.0–0 c5 12.♞xc4 cxd4 13.♗xa8!?

This is the maximalist try.

13.♞xd4N e5 14.♞d3 is a safe alternative, when White keeps a solid positional edge due to Black's weak pawn structure.

13...♞xa8 14.♞xd4 e5 15.♞h4 h6 16.♖c4 ♗e7

All this happened in Mamrukov – Salvatore, corr. 2013. Here I believe White should play:



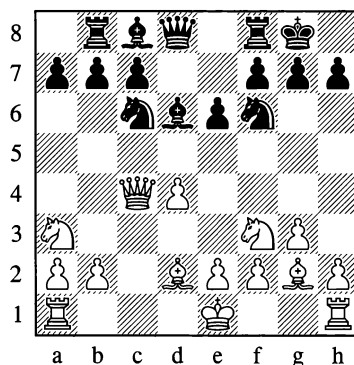
17.♗g5!N 0–0 18.♗xf6 ♗xf6 19.♞h5 ♞e4 20.♖e3 ♗c6 21.♞f3 ♞xf3 22.exf3 ♗xf3 23.♞ac1

Black does not have enough for the exchange.

8...♞b8 9.♞xc4!

Obviously the main idea behind Black's last move was to meet 9.♖xc4 with 9...b5, after which 10.♖xd6† cxd6 11.♞c2 ♗b7 left Black in good shape in Michalik – Zakhartsov, Aix-les-Bains 2011.

9...0–0



10.0–0N

This natural move is much stronger than 10.♗d1?! ♗d7 11.♞c2 ♞e7= as occurred in Beliavsky – Farago, Hungary 1998.

10...♗d7

10...e5 is no problem due to 11.dxe5 ♖xe5 12.♖xe5 ♗xe5 13.♞c2!, intending ♖c4, when White gets nice play.

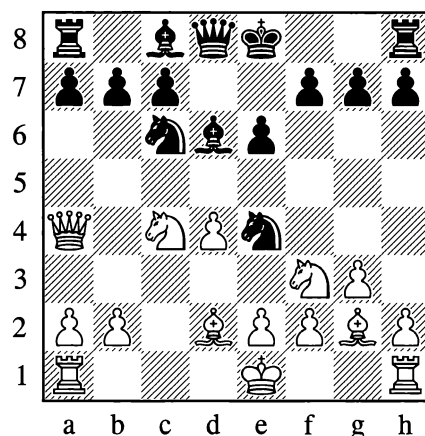
11.♞ac1 ♞e7 12.♞d3

Preparing ♖c4.

12...e5 13.dxe5 ♖xe5 14.♖xe5 ♗xe5 15.♖c4 ♗b5 16.♞b3 ♗xc4 17.♞xc4

White's bishop pair should enable him to exert long-term pressure.

D11) 8...♖e4 9.♖xc4



9...♖xd2

I neglected to mention 9...0–0 in *GM 1*. White has two decent replies:

a) 10.e3 seems fine, and after 10...♙d7 11.♖b3 the position resembles the main line below, and an exact transposition might occur after 11...♟xd2 12.♟fxd2. The engine suggests 11...b5 instead, but 12.♟ce5 looks better for White.

b) 10.♙e3!? is a more ambitious alternative. After 10...♙b4† 11.♟f1 White has lost the opportunity to castle, but Black's pieces are shaky in the centre and White preserves an obvious space advantage. After 11...♟f6 12.♞d1 ♙e7 13.a3 a5 14.♙c1 ♞a6 15.♖c2 White was better in Shimanov – Frolyanov, Irkutsk 2010.

10.♟fxd2

10.♟cxd2 0–0 11.0–0 enables Black to carry out his main idea of 11...e5, with complicated play.

10...♙d7

10...0–0 gives White the useful option of 11.♙xc6! (11.e3 is obviously fine, and may transpose to the main line) 11...bxc6 12.0–0 with a favourable change in the pawn structure. After the natural sequence 12...c5 13.dxc5 ♙xc5 14.♞fd1 ♙d7 15.♖c2 Black is under unpleasant pressure, and there is every chance for the white knights to outwork the enemy bishops.

11.e3!?

I found no reason to change the recommendation from *GM 1*.

11...0–0 12.♖b3 b5

This looks like the most challenging continuation.

12...♞b8 enables White to comfortably meet the ...e5 advance with: 13.♞c1 e5N (The only game here saw the rather passive 13...♖e7 14.0–0 ♞fc8. In Iskusnyh – Vasilov, Samara

2011, the strong 15.f4!N would have secured a solid positional advantage.) 14.d5 ♟e7 15.♟e4! White has a clear plus.

13.♟xd6

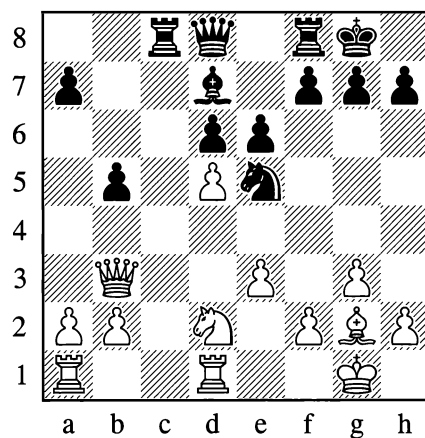
13.♟e5 could be checked, but I am not sure how to assess the situation after 13...♟xe5 14.dxe5 ♙xe5 15.♙xa8 ♖xa8 16.0–0 ♙c6.

13...cxd6 14.d5!

Otherwise White has nothing special.

14...♟e5 15.0–0 ♞c8 16.♞fd1

Previously I assessed this as slightly better for White, and I found one practical example.

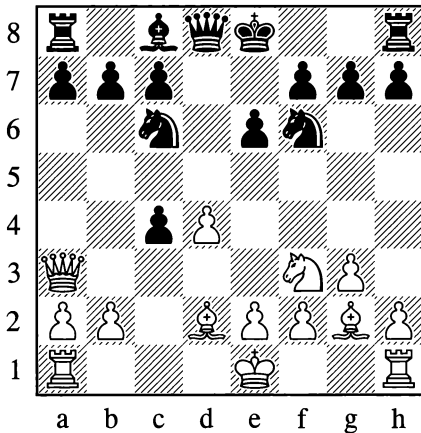


16...♞b6 17.♙h3! exd5 18.♙xd7 ♟xd7 19.♖xd5 ♞c5 20.♖d4 ♖c6 21.♖e4!

White obtained a favourable situation playing against the isolated pawn in Murin – Pavlicek, email 2012.

D12) 8...♙xa3 9.♖xa3

After 9.bxa3 ♖d5! 10.0–0 b5 11.♖d1 (or 11.♖c2 ♙b7) 11...♙b7 Black was perfectly okay in Loetscher – Doettling, Pula 2003.

**9...♗e4**

This is the main continuation, but Black has two other moves:

So far nobody has grabbed the second pawn with 9...♖xd4 10.♖xd4 ♗xd4, which is understandable, as 11.♗d1♖ gives White fantastic compensation. His bishops are strong and the black monarch will most probably have to remain in the centre for a long time.

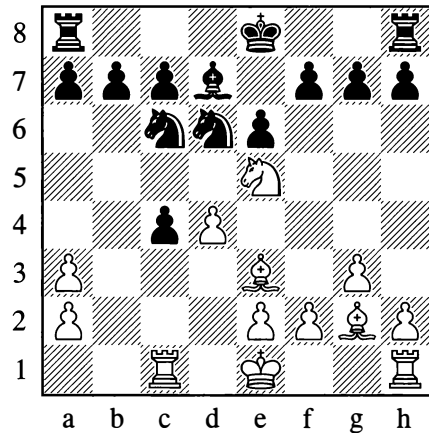
9...♗d6 10.♗c1 (10.♗c3!? has also been played successfully, but I would prefer to regain the pawn without any adventures.) 10...♗xa3 11.bxa3 ♕d7 12.♗xc4 0–0–0 13.0–0 ♖d5 14.♗fc1 f6 15.♗c2± After a logical sequence, White retained an edge thanks to his bishop pair in Ingersol – Mueller, email 2011.

10.♕e3 ♗d6 11.♗c1 ♗xa3

11...0–0N might soon transpose after 12.♖e5, but Black's last move gives White the useful extra option of 12.♗a4, avoiding any damage to the queenside structure.

12.bxa3 ♖d6 13.♖e5 ♕d7

13...♖xe5?! 14.dxe5 ♖f5 15.♕d2 reaches a difficult position for Black.

**14.♖xc4**

After 14.0–0 f6 15.♖xc4 ♖f5 16.♗fd1 ♖xe3 17.♖xe3 0–0–0 18.♖c4 ♗he8 19.e3± White retained definite pressure thanks to the powerful Catalan bishop in Tkachiev – Schenk, Gonfreville 2006. Nevertheless, I like the text move even more.

14...♖f5 15.♕f4 ♗c8

After 15...♖fxd4? 16.♕xc7 0–0 17.♖d6± Black is most probably going to lose his b7-pawn.

Another game continued 15...0–0–0 16.e3 ♖fe7 17.g4! h5 18.h3 hxg4 19.hxg4± and White retained the usual pressure thanks to his bishop pair in Godat – Muttoni, email 2009.

16.e3 f6

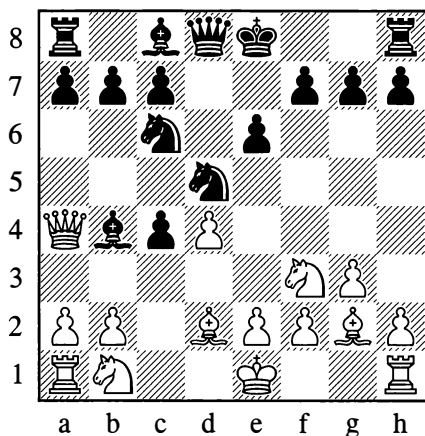
In *GM I* I mentioned 16...♖fe7 17.g4, when White preserved the dark-squared bishop and maintained a pleasant advantage in Gustafsson – Khenkin, Altenkirchen 2005. The text move was played in a more recent game, but it changes nothing.

17.g4 ♖fe7

This occurred in Cernousek – Haba, Czech Republic 2011, and now the right idea for White would have been:

18.h4N 0-0 19.♖g1!?

White has an enduring edge, the main factor being the bishop pair once again.

D2) 7...♟d5**8.♞b5!?**

In *GM 1* I mentioned this as an interesting alternative to 8.♟xb4 ♟dxb4, which I gave as my main recommendation. Since then the theory has developed a lot in this line, and Black currently seems to be close to equality. I will not go into further details about this, other than mentioning that 9.♟c3 ♟d7 10.0-0 a5 11.♞d1 0-0 12.e3 a4 is one important line that I looked at.

Black can either return the c4-pawn with **D21) 8...0-0**, or play for a material advantage with the critical **D22) 8...♟xd2†**.

D21) 8...0-0 9.♞xc4 ♟b6

This is obviously one of the ideas behind Black's 7th move.

10.♞d3 e5

This pawn push is highly thematic for this variation. Black can also do it after trading bishops: 10...♟xd2† 11.♟bxd2 e5 Now White should simply play 12.♟xe5, transposing

to the main line. (Instead after 12.dxe5?! ♞xd3 13.exd3 ♟d8 Black was doing well in Zubritskiy – Duzhakov, St Petersburg 2014.)

11.♟xe5!

I overlooked this move in *GM 1*, but it is the only way to fight for the advantage.

11...♟xd2† 12.♟xd2 ♟xd4

A natural alternative is:

12...♟b4 13.♞b1!

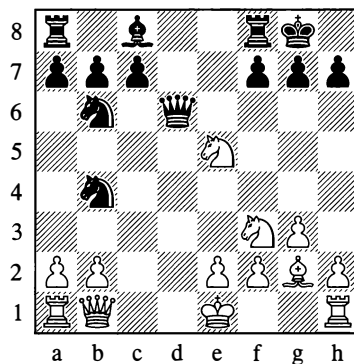
This is the best retreat square, avoiding the queen trade.

13...♞xd4 14.♟df3

White is not about to refute his opponent's set-up, but his superior piece coordination and extra central pawn should offer him a persistent edge.

14...♞d6

Another good example is: 14...♞d8 15.a3 ♟d4d5 16.0-0 ♞e7 17.♞c2 a5 18.♞ad1 a4 19.e4 ♟f6 20.♞fe1 ♟e6 De Boer – So. Polgar, Breda 1996. Black is pretty solid, but I like White's position after 21.♞c1N c6 22.♟d4±. In this type of structure it is always easier for White to advance his pawn majority.

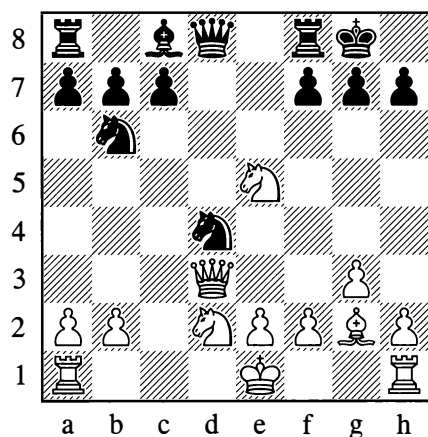
**15.0-0 ♞e8**

15...f6 16.♞d1 ♞e7 17.a3 ♟a6 (White is also better after 17...fxe5 18.axb4 ♟f5 19.♞c1±) 18.♟d3 c5 19.b4! c4 20.♟b2 ♟e6 21.♟d4 ♟f7 22.♞c2 White kept an advantage due

to the passivity of the black knights in W. Schiller – Markus, email 2008.

16.♞d1 ♞e7 17.a3 ♟d4d5 18.e4 ♟f6 19.♞c2 c6 20.♞e1 ♞c7 21.♞c3 a5 22.h3±

This was Deep Junior – Hiarc, Internet 2012. Once again, White's advantage is not huge, but his pieces are much better coordinated, his e4-pawn is restricting Black's minor pieces, and he has the more mobile pawn majority.



13.e3 ♟f5

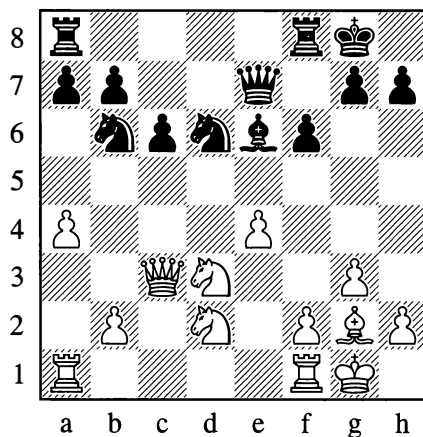
Black has also tried: 13...♟e6 14.♞c3!N (White should keep the queens on the board, since after 14.♞xd8 ♞xd8 the arising endgame was perfectly playable for Black in Chabanon – Lautier, Aix-les-Bains 2003, and he soon got the upper hand after further unconvincing play from White) 14...♞e7 (14...♟d5 15.♞b3 c6 16.0-0 is also slightly better for White) 15.0-0 c6 16.♟df3 ♟d5 17.♞c2 White has a typical slight plus, for similar reasons to those mentioned in the lines above.

14.♞c3

Once again, White should avoid the queen exchange. The less challenging 14.♞xd8 ♞xd8 15.♟e2 was seen in Mads – Harutyunian, Yerevan 2014, and now 15...♞e8N 16.♟d3 c6 would have left Black with no serious problems.

14...♞e7 15.0-0 c6 16.e4 ♟d6 17.a4! ♟e6 18.♟d3 f6

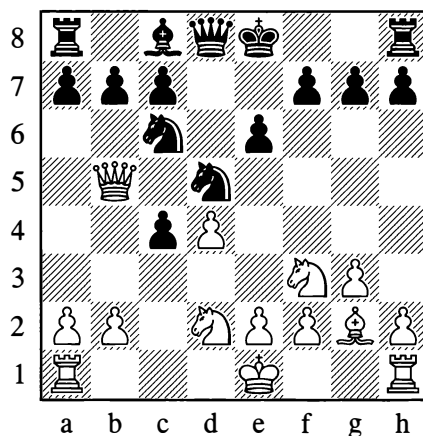
We have been following Tosi – Andersen, corr. 2011. Here I favour:



19.♞fe1!N ♞ad8 20.♟f3

White has a definite edge, as his pieces are better coordinated and the e4-pawn limits the movement of Black's minor pieces.

D22) 8...♟xd2† 9.♟bxd2



9...c3

Black does best to accept the challenge, otherwise he may find himself in a worse position without many active prospects. 9...♟b6 10.♟e5!N

But not 10. ♖xc4 ♜d5 11. ♖a3 a6 12. ♜d3 e5! 13. dxe5 ♜xd3 14. exd3 ♙f5 and Black was fine in Ulibin – Arnaudov, Marrakesh 2010.

10... ♜xd4

I also considered 10... 0-0 11. ♖xc6 (11. ♙xc6!? bxc6 12. ♜c5 is an interesting alternative) 11... bxc6 12. ♜c5 ♜d6 13. 0-0 ♜b8 14. ♜fd1± which looks promising for White.

11. ♖xc6

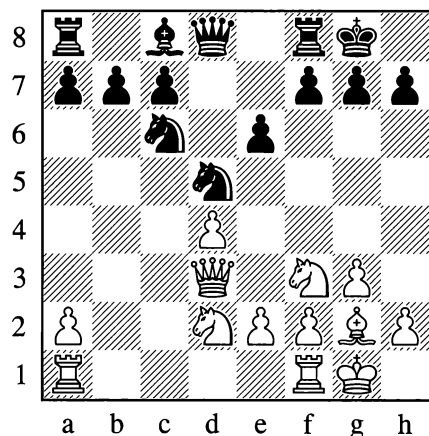
11. e3 ♜d6 12. ♖xc6 ♙d7 13. ♖xc4 ♖xc4 14. ♜xc4 ♙xc6 15. ♜d1 ♙xg2 16. ♜xd6 cxd6 17. ♙g1 ♙d5 18. ♜a4† ♙c6 19. ♜b4 0-0 is not so clear.

11... bxc6 12. ♙xc6† ♙d7 13. 0-0-0 ♙xc6 14. ♜xc6† ♜d7 15. ♜xd7† ♖xd7 16. ♖xc4±

White has an enduring advantage thanks to his better pawn structure.

10.bxc3 ♖xc3 11. ♜d3 ♖d5 12.0-0 0-0

After a relatively forced sequence of moves, we have reached an important position for the 8. ♜b5!? line. Black has a healthy extra pawn, while White has a significant space advantage, along with open b- and c-files, and the clear superiority of the Catalan bishop over its counterpart on c8. These factors promise White long-term compensation, although accurate play will be required to prevent Black from untangling his queenside.



13. ♜fc1

It is best to start with this move. It is useful to remain flexible, especially with regard to the e-pawn, which may advance one or two squares.

13...h6

I will take this as the main line, as it was used by Frolyanov to draw with Ponomarev. Three other moves have been tried:

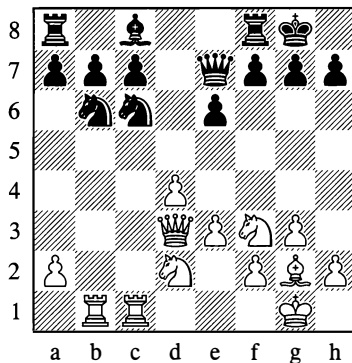
13... ♜e7 gives White more than one decent option. 14. ♜ab1N (There is also 14. e4 ♖b6 15. ♜e3, transposing to the game Duzhakov – Eryshkanova, St Petersburg 2011, which continued 15... ♜d8 16. ♖b3 with good compensation.) 14... ♜d8 15. a3 f6 16. e3 ♜f7 17. ♜c5± With continuing pressure for the pawn.

13... ♖b6 14. ♜ab1 ♜e7

Here I found an improvement.

15. e3!?N

After the more aggressive 15. h4 h6 16. e4 ♜d8 17. ♜e3 ♙d7 18. g4 ♙e8 Black's defensive resources proved more than adequate in Gundavaa – Zhao, Khanty-Mansiysk (ol) 2010.



15...f6

15... ♜d8 runs into the tactical trick 16. ♜xc6! bxc6 17. ♖e5 ♜f8 18. ♖xc6 ♙e8 19. ♖e4± with great compensation.

16.♖e1 ♖d5

16...♗d7 is met by 17.♖e4 followed by the unpleasant ♖c5.

17.♗c4 ♗d8 18.♖d3

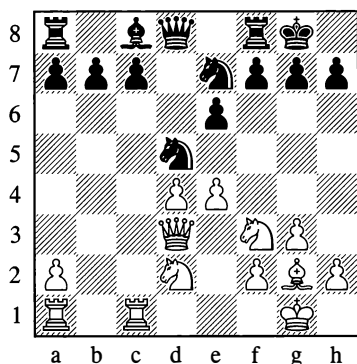
White has regrouped his pieces in the ideal way.

13...♖ce7

This is a slightly more challenging move, intending ...b6 followed by ...♗b7. I believe White should react by switching to a different plan.

14.e4!N

14.♗ab1 has been played a couple of times, but it allows 14...b6N 15.e4 ♖f6 followed by ...♗b7, which is something I would like to prevent.

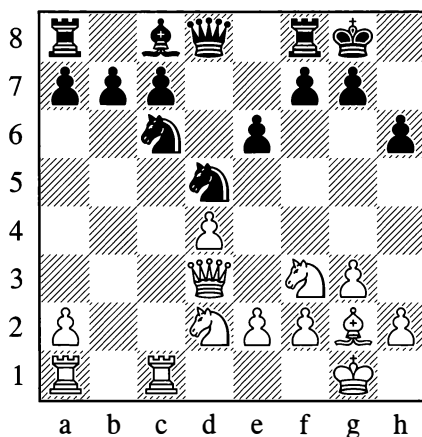


14...♖b4

14...♖f6 is met by 15.♗c3 c6 16.♖e5 when Black is still a long way from solving the problem of the passive bishop on c8.

15.♗c3 ♖bc6 16.♗d1 b6 17.♖c4! ♗b7 18.♖e3

Black has succeeded in developing his light-squared bishop, but White has arranged his pieces harmoniously and is ready to seize the initiative in the centre by means of d4-d5.



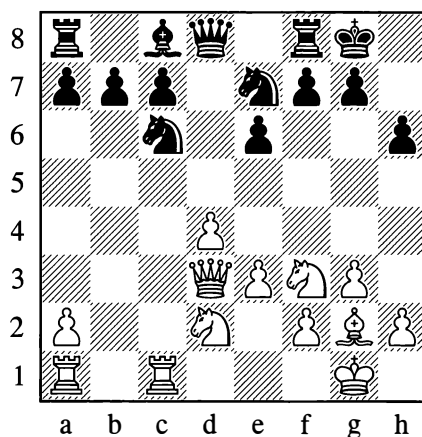
14.e3!N

As you may have noticed from some of the previous lines, I would tend to favour this set-up unless there is a compelling reason not to.

14.♗ab1 was used successfully by Tkachiev in the stem game, which I quoted in *GM 1*. However, Black subsequently improved with 14...♖de7!, and after 15.♖b3 a5 16.♗c2 ♗a7 17.e3 b6 18.a3 ♗b7 19.♖bd2 ♗a8 he easily solved his problems in Ponomarev – Frolyanov, Olginka 2011.

14...♖de7

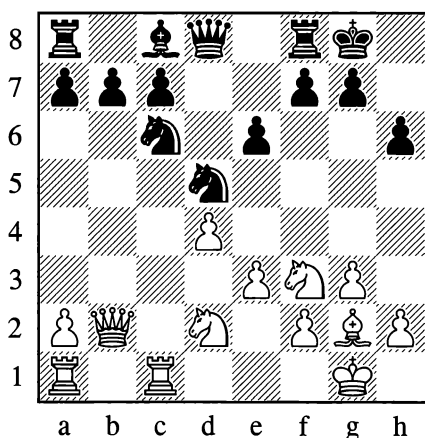
14...♗e7 15.♗ab1 ♗d8 16.a3 ♖b6 17.♗c3 ♖d5 18.♗b2 does not really alter the evaluation.



15. ♖c3! ♕d5

An important detail is that 15...b6 is impossible due to 16. ♖e5!.

16. ♖b2



White retains solid compensation.

Conclusion

After 5... ♖c6 6. ♖a4 we covered four main branches. 6... ♗d6 is playable, but the ambitious 7. ♖e5!? damages Black's queenside structure, leading to an advantage for White with correct play. The three other branches are rather more popular.

6... ♗d7 7. ♖xc4 ♖a5 8. ♖d3 c5 9. 0-0 is out of fashion for Black, but it should not be forgotten. The most popular continuation is 9... ♗c6 10. ♖c3, when White's lead in development gives him a pleasant initiative. An important recurring theme is seen in positions where Black exchanges on d4 and g2, after which a timely queen check on b5 may seriously disrupt Black's development.

6... ♖d7 7. ♖xc4 ♖b6 is another important line, when 8. ♖b5! is an important refinement. Most of the recommendations are similar to those in *GM 1*, with just a few refinements here and there.

Finally, 6... ♗b4† 7. ♗d2 gives Black a choice. 7... ♗d6 is quite playable, when the position of the bishop on d2 instead of c1 gives White good reason to take a different path from variation A. 8. ♖a3 is my preference, and my analysis shows that it leads to an edge, regardless of whether Black tries to eliminate the bishop with 8... ♖e4 or gives up his own bishop with 8... ♗xa3. The other main option is 7... ♖d5, after which 8. ♖b5!? has gone from being my number-two suggestion in *GM 1* to my top recommendation here. The critical line involves a pawn sacrifice, after which my analysis shows that White can obtain a lasting initiative.